Chapter 2: From Villages to Cities

The River Valleys

About ten thousand years ago, people in many parts of the world began to grow their own food. The first farmers settled near rivers such as the **Indus**, because the floods left behind rich **silt** that made the soil fertile.

The story of farming villages begins with ordinary people who needed food, water and safety, and it changed how they lived for centuries. Historians study farming villages from the remains people left behind: pots, seals, walls and the bones of animals. Each new find adds a little to what we know, and sometimes it overturns an old idea about farming villages completely.

The story of the river valleys begins with ordinary people who needed food, water and safety, and it changed how they lived for centuries. Historians study the river valleys from the remains people left behind: pots, seals, walls and the bones of animals. Each new find adds a little to what we know, and sometimes it overturns an old idea about the river valleys completely.

> **Do you know?** The Nile flooded at almost the same time every year, so Egyptian farmers could plan their sowing by the calendar.

Because farmers could now grow more grain than they needed, a **surplus** appeared. Some people no longer had to farm: they became potters, weavers and traders.

The story of the surplus begins with ordinary people who needed food, water and safety, and it changed how they lived for centuries. Historians study the surplus from the remains people left behind: pots, seals, walls and the bones of animals. Each new find adds a little to what we know, and sometimes it overturns an old idea about the surplus completely.

The First Cities

Around 2600 BCE, cities such as **Harappa** and **Mohenjo-daro** grew up in the Indus valley. Their streets were laid out in a grid, and covered **drains** ran along them.

The story of Harappan cities begins with ordinary people who needed food, water and safety, and it changed how they lived for centuries. Historians study Harappan cities from the remains people left behind: pots, seals, walls and the bones of animals. Each new find adds a little to what we know, and sometimes it overturns an old idea about Harappan cities completely.

The story of town planning begins with ordinary people who needed food, water and safety, and it changed how they lived for centuries. Historians study town planning from the remains people left behind: pots, seals, walls and the bones of animals. Each new find adds a little to what we know, and sometimes it overturns an old idea about town planning completely.

Each city had a large **granary** where grain was stored, and a raised area that historians call the **citadel**.

> **Activity** Draw a plan of your own street and mark where the water drains away.

The story of the citadel begins with ordinary people who needed food, water and safety, and it changed how they lived for centuries. Historians study the citadel from the remains people left behind: pots, seals, walls and the bones of animals. Each new find adds a little to what we know, and sometimes it overturns an old idea about the citadel completely.

Trade and Writing

Harappan traders exchanged goods with far-off lands such as Mesopotamia. They used stone **seals** carved with animals and signs to mark their goods.

The story of trade begins with ordinary people who needed food, water and safety, and it changed how they lived for centuries. Historians study trade from the remains people left behind: pots, seals, walls and the bones of animals. Each new find adds a little to what we know, and sometimes it overturns an old idea about trade completely.

The story of the Harappan script begins with ordinary people who needed food, water and safety, and it changed how they lived for centuries. Historians study the Harappan script from the remains people left behind: pots, seals, walls and the bones of animals. Each new find adds a little to what we know, and sometimes it overturns an old idea about the Harappan script completely.

The signs on the seals are a kind of writing, but nobody has yet been able to read the **Harappan script**.

Exercises

1. Why did the first farmers settle near rivers?

2. What was a surplus, and how did it change village life?

3. Which of these was found in Harappan cities?
(a) Iron tools (b) Covered drains (c) Coins (d) Paper

4. Why can historians not read the Harappan script?